



SUFFERERS FOR LONG
Among a group of women at Bermajur village, one displays the title deed of land taken away from her; inset, TMC leader Sheikh Shahjahan being produced in court after his arrest, Feb. 29

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Sandeshkhali, in South Bengal, has always been in the eye of a storm. The riverine area, resting cheek-by-jowl with the Sunderbans and the sea, has long been pummelled by cyclones. But the continual tempest of tyranny that villagers, especially women, allege has been lashing them for over a decade has only just ceased. By all accounts, it's a tale of subverting justice and the wheels of administration for personal gain and influence. The undisputed villain of the piece, they say, is local Trinamool Congress (TMC) strongman Sheikh Shahjahan and his followers. The most damaging charge levelled against him: persistent sexual assault and abuse of women. As news of Shahjahan's arrest broke, it was women who burst into celebration, splashing colours and distributing sweets. And as INDIA TODAY visited the hamlet of Sandeshkhali—which is criss-crossed by rivers, making it practically an island—and neighbouring villages, it was women who spoke up most readily. They had reason to feel vindicated. Ask Urmila Das of Jeliakhali village, whose son has been on the run since Shahjahan's motorbike-borne men beat him up for not meeting their demands. Or her neighbour Shefali Das. "TMC men would ask us to attend party meetings. They would come at night and take us to party offices," she recalls. What happened at many of those meetings has made national headlines. "If they come out (of custody), they will kill us all," Shefali expresses her worst fears. Urmila and Shefali allege that all law and order issues would be directly or indirectly dealt by Shahjahan and his men, whose writ ran unopposed in these parts. Dissenters would be brutalised.

The West Bengal Police arrested the TMC leader and zilla parishad member on February 29 for allegedly provoking a mob assault on an Enforcement Directorate (ED) team that had gone to raid his residence on January 5 in connection with a ration distribution scam. Shahjahan had been a fugitive since then; his run from the law lasted 55 days. But that one incident that had catapulted him to national notoriety opened a can of worms. Starting from February 7, the villages that had been the stomping ground of the TMC strongman—in Sandeshkhali Block I and II, in Basirhat subdivision of North 24 Parganas district—erupted in spontaneous and unprecedented protests against the alleged misdeeds of Shahjahan and his associates. At the forefront were women who, other than accusing Shahjahan and his henchmen, particularly Uttam Sardar, Shibaprasad Hazra and Ajit Maity (the three were arrested days before their leader) of sexual crimes, also charged them with widespread land-grabbing. With a major scandal blowing up in the face of the TMC government a few months before the Lok Sabha polls, the state's main Opposition party, the BJP, as well as the CPI(M), jumped in to make political capital out of Shahjahan's 'reign of terror'. Though